

Caroline Edwards



Good design starts with understanding people, not just their data.

About me

Design philosophy

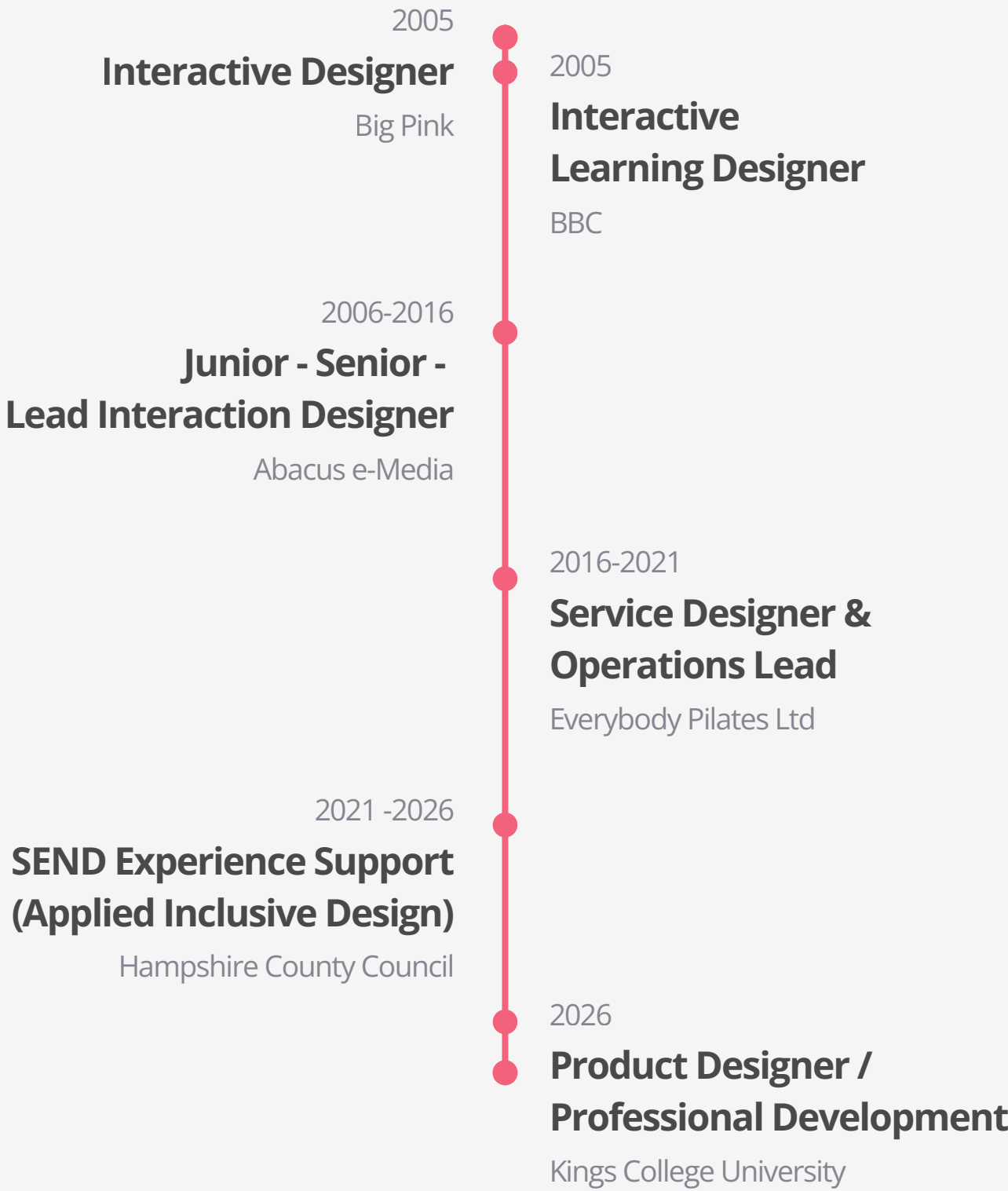
Start with the problem, not the solution.

What I bring

Curiosity, evidence and ownership.

How I work

Understand → question → test → learn → adapt.



What do I know?

Problem

Discover

The charity wants to investigate whether digitising ordering and payment could make restaurant work more accessible for people with learning difficulties.

Define

The existing service asks staff to perform tasks that create cognitive, visual and social barriers

Make/Test

The MVP needs to explore a service that allows staff to:

Learn/Iterate

- Take drinks orders
- Understand and record orders accurately
- Communicate orders to the bar
- Deliver drinks to customers
- Avoid unnecessary reading/cognitive load
- Reduce the need to interact directly with customers around payment

Reflect

Service ecosystem

Primary users

Restaurant employees

From the brief we know:

- Some have poor eyesight
- Some have reduced cognitive ability
- Some have limited reading skills
- They respond better to symbols/simple images
- They prefer to avoid customer interaction
- Payment is particularly challenging

Secondary users

Restaurant customers

They need to:

- Order what they want
- Understand/confirm their order
- Receive their drinks
- Pay
- Have a reasonably smooth restaurant experience

Operational stakeholders

Restaurant staff & managers

- Receive accurate orders
- Prepare drinks
- Keep service moving
- Work with the new system
- See enough benefit to adopt it

The charity

- Support meaningful employment
- Enable staff independence
- Demonstrate the model works
- Get restaurant buy-in
- Determine whether the concept is worth scaling

Our goals

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

Primary user goal

Take and deliver orders confidently and independently.

Secondary user goal

Enjoy a simple, friction-free restaurant experience.

Business goal - restaurant

Maintain accurate orders without slowing down service.

Business goal - charity

Prove the model can scale to more restaurants and create more paid jobs.

The challenge

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

“ How might we
**reduce the barriers to ordering &
payment so employees can work more
independently - while creating a service
restaurants can confidently adopt & scale? ”**

Current service experience

	1 Choose Customer decides	2 Order Customer says their order	3 Record The order is recorded	4 Prepare Drinks are made	5 Deliver Drinks go to the table	6 Pay The bill is settled	7 Complete The order closes
Customer What they do	Reads the menu and decides.	Says their order out loud.	Waits while it is written down.	Waits for the drinks.	Receives drinks at the table.	Asks for the bill and pays.	Carries on with their visit.
Employee What they do	Approaches the table.	Listens and tries to hold the whole order in memory.	Writes it down, or asks a colleague to enter it.	Waits at the bar, unsure when it will be ready.	Finds the table and delivers the drinks.	Handles the card machine or cash.	Returns to the floor for the next table.
Restaurant staff What they do	—	—	Takes the order verbally and enters it on the till.	Makes the drinks.	—	Processes payment, or steps in to help.	—
Independence Can the employee do this without help?	✓ Can do alone	! Finds it hard	✗ Needs support	! Finds it hard	✓ Can do alone	✗ Needs support	✓ Can do alone
Pain points & opportunities What's not working? What could we do?	Menu is text-heavy and hard to understand. Use clear images and simple language.	Hard to remember order, increasing errors. Capture the order digitally as it's spoken.	Reading and writing may be a barrier to recording the order. Use a simple visual interface to record orders.	No signal when drinks are ready, leading to uncertainty. Show clear visual and audible notifications when ready.	May deliver to the wrong table. Clearly display table number with the order.	Card machines and cash are difficult and can cause anxiety. Enable contactless or table payment to reduce interaction.	No confirmation it worked, which can be stressful. Show a clear success message and next steps.

Assumptions

Lower-risk / given by brief

- Staff have varied reading/visual/cognitive needs.
- Staff respond better to symbols/simple images.
- Staff prefer to avoid customer interaction.
- Staff struggle with payment.
- The service involves drink orders and delivery.
- The proof of concept lasts 8–12 weeks.

Important / need to validate

- Visual symbols will be understood consistently.
- Staff can confidently use a touchscreen.
- A job coach/support worker can contribute to research and testing.
- Other restaurant staff can provide support when needed.
- Customers will be comfortable with the proposed interaction.
- Existing restaurant technology can support the new service.

Critical assumptions / potential blockers

- EPOS/payment integration
- What happens if the system fails during service?
- Whether the restaurant workflow can accommodate the new process
- Whether the proposed service actually reduces, rather than shifts, the cognitive burden

Who I'd involve

A mix of people to ensure the solution works for everyone

Employees

Understand the current service and co-design the solution

Support staff

Consider individual needs and ensure an inclusive approach

Customers

Understand their experience and test ordering and payment

Restaurants

Assess operations feasibility and identify adoption barriers

Charity stakeholders

Ensure strategic fit and define success

How I'd learn

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

Research with people not about people

01 Observe → Watch the service in context

02 Understand → Interviews + accessibility needs

03 Co-design → Explore solutions with users

04 Prototype → Turn ideas into testable flows

05 Test → Test with real users

06 Pilot → Learn in a live restaurant

The opportunity



Problem

Discover

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Make/Test

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Reflect

Make choice easier - Visual, recognisable and predictable.

Remove cognitive burden - Don't make the employee remember, interpret or translate an order.

Make progress obvious - Clear feedback at every stage.

Protect independence - Remove unnecessary social/payment pressure and keep the employee in control.

Design principles

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

01

Accessible by default

Everyone gets the same accessible foundation.

02

Personal, not prescribed

A small number of tested choices allow the experience to adapt without creating configuration burden.

03

The person stays in control

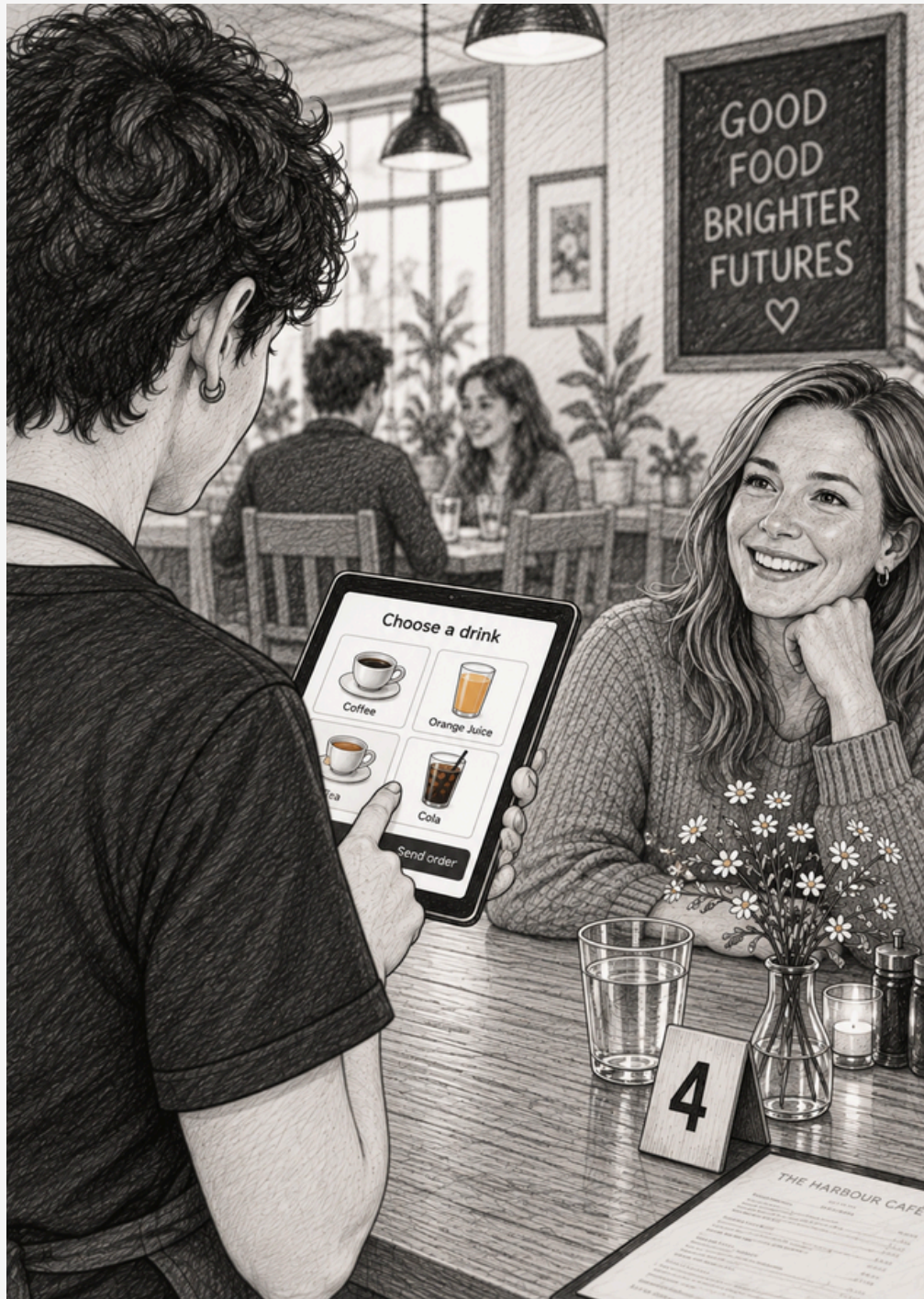
The employee chooses their experience; support staff enable rather than decide.

04

Familiar wherever they work

The experience should follow the person, not the restaurant or device.

Concept A



Employee-led

The visual companion

The tablet provides

- Photo/symbol-led drinks
- Very large touch targets
- Minimal text
- Clear table identification
- Order confirmation
- Ready-to-deliver notification
- Clear completion

Potential solution

Keeps the employee at the centre of the service while removing much of the reading, memory and writing burden.

Risk / question

Does the employee still feel pressure from having to interact with the customer?

Concept B



Customer-led

Scan & Order

Potential solution

Removes ordering memory burden. Removes much of the customer conversation.

Removes payment from the employee. Potentially reduces order errors

Risk / question

Does removing the ordering interaction also remove an important part of the employee's role?

It solves several of the immediate problems, but potentially at the cost of independence and meaningful participation. Also relies on the hardware of the customer - could it be a complete barrier for many visitors.

Concept C



Shared / assisted

The table hub

Potential solution

It takes the memory and writing burden away from the employee without completely removing them from the ordering experience.

Risk / question

Does a shared device create a more complicated interaction than either person needs?
This is potentially bespoke hardware with a larger cost to the business

Choosing what to take forward

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

Criteria

Employee keeps a meaningful job

Reduced cognitive effort

Payment pressure eased

Buildable in 8-12 weeks

Cost to the restaurant

Who it excludes

A

Yes

Yes

Yes

Yes

Medium

–

B

No

Yes

Yes

Yes

Low

No smartphone
No payment card

C

Yes

No

Yes

Yes

High

–

Define MVP

Problem

What is the smallest thing we need to prove?

Discover

Employee → Can they complete orders more independently?

Define

Customer → Can they have a friction-free cafe experience?

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Restaurant → Can orders move through the existing workflow without additional burden?

Reflect

Charity → Can this model be repeated across partner restaurants?

One interface. Different levels of support.

The employee stays in control.

Internal wireframes

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

01

Internal MVP wireframe

Establish the structure, map interaction logic, challenge assumptions

02

Higher-fidelity MVP prototype

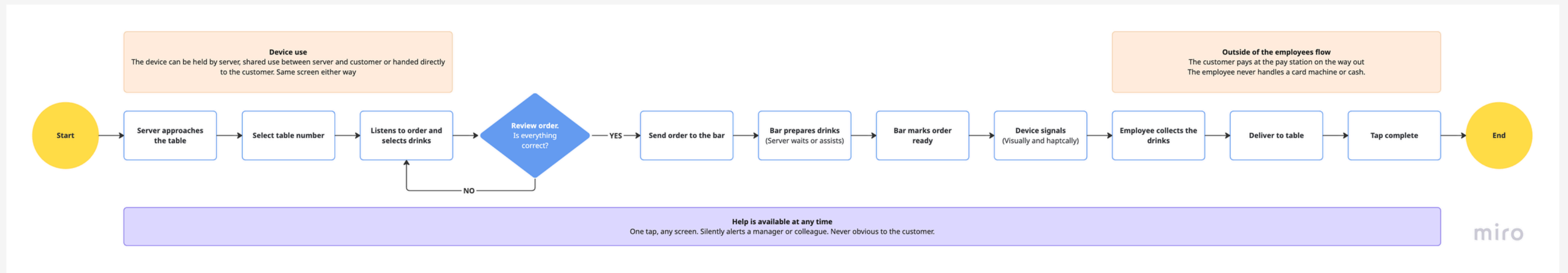
- make the interface understandable without explanation
- test the actual visual/interaction model
- test cognitive load
- observe independence and confidence
- test the three interaction modes

03

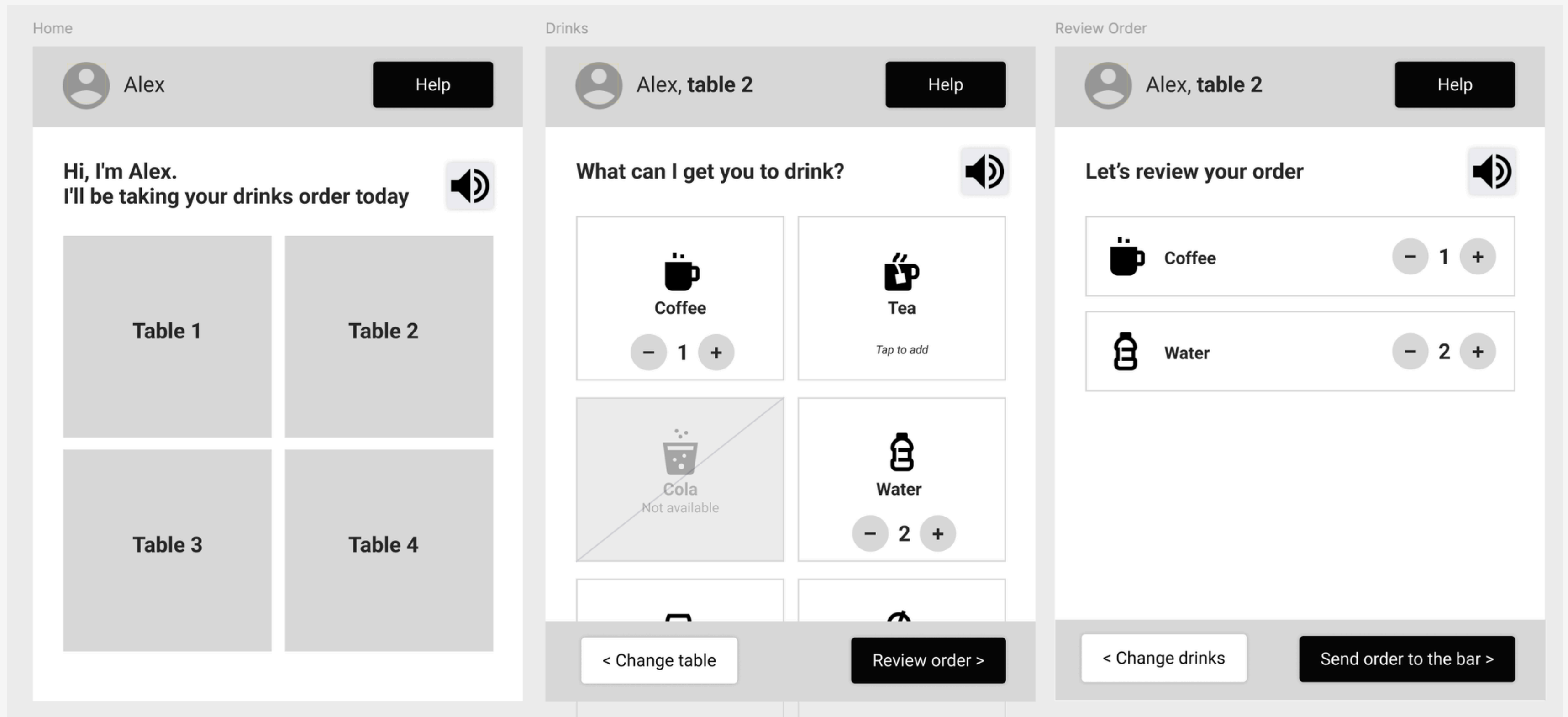
Initial user testing

I can then test the product rather than asking users to interpret the interface

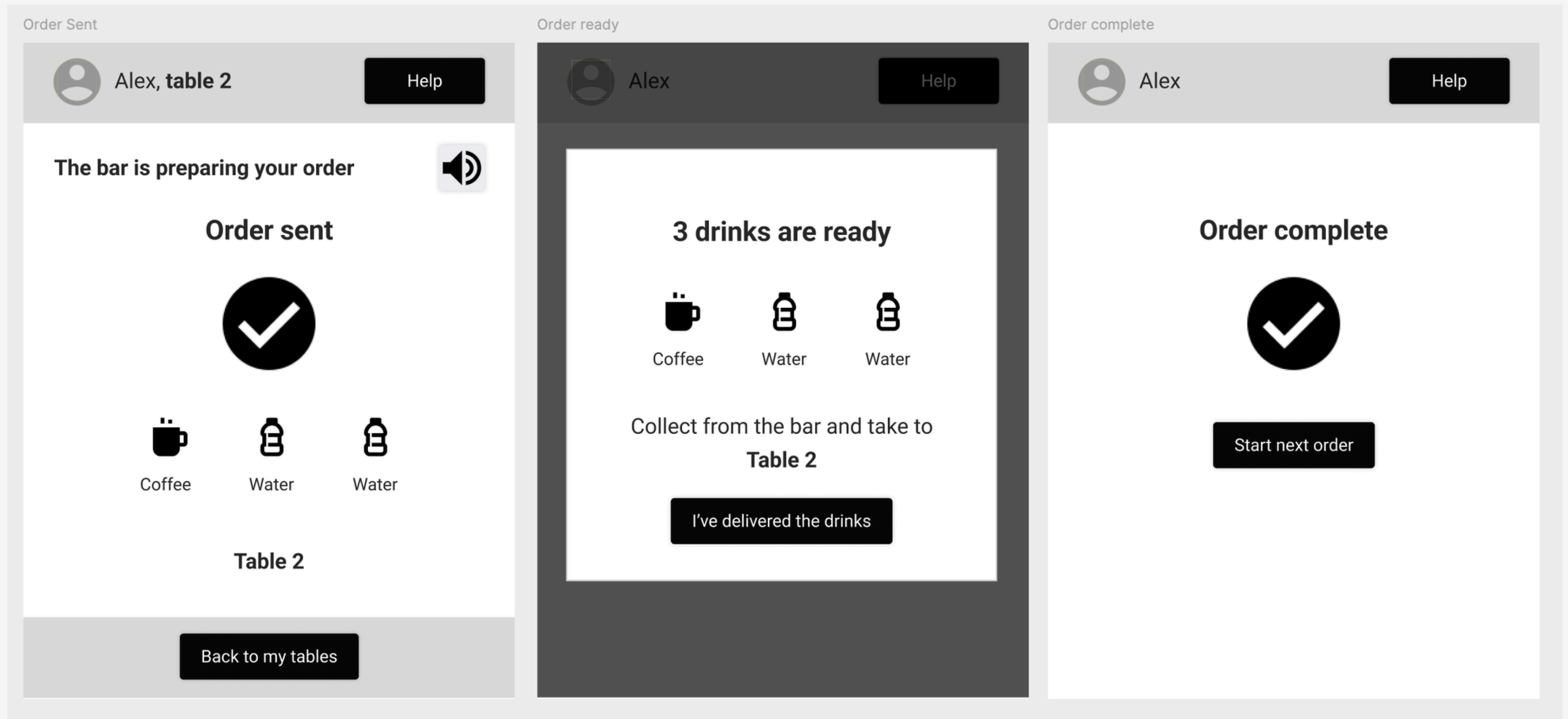
User flow



MVP wireframes



MVP wireframes



Initial usability testing

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

For this audience, low-fidelity testing may introduce unnecessary cognitive load.

Wireframes require users to interpret unfamiliar representations, placeholder content and interaction patterns. That risks testing comprehension of the prototype rather than comprehension of the service.

High fidelity doesn't mean fully designed.

Hi-Fi demo

Problem

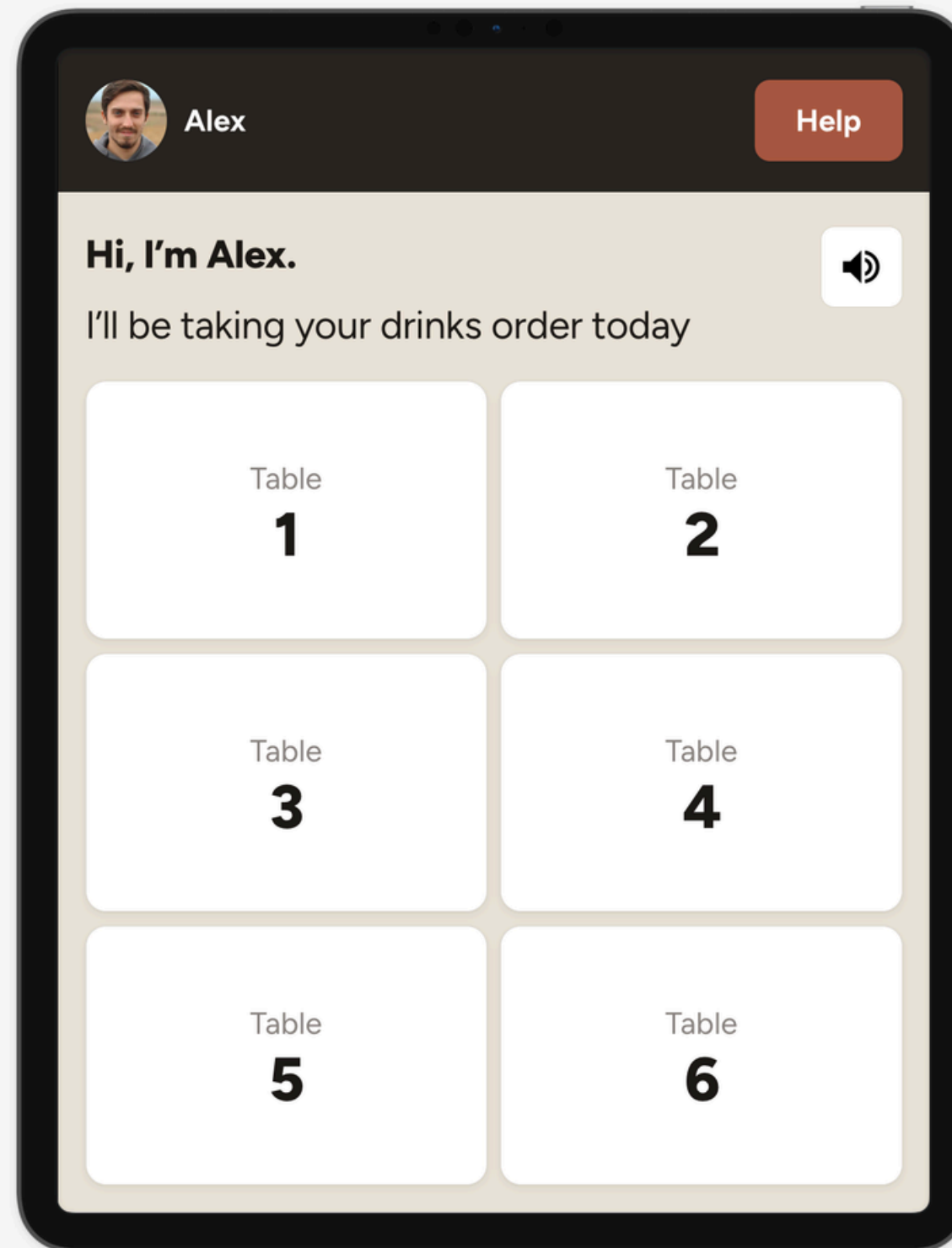
Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect



Test plan

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

The test plan				
	When	Stimulus	Question	Measures
0 Baseline	Wk 1–2	Existing service	What happens today?	Independence, errors, time, support
1 Visuals	Wk 3–4	Printed tiles + real drinks	Can people recognise and select the right drink?	Accuracy, time, hesitation, repeatability
2 Hi-fi	Wk 5–6	High-fidelity prototype + real device	Can the order be completed without unnecessary support?	Independence, errors, recovery, support
3 Retest	Wk 6–7	Revised prototype	Did the changes work?	Same measures + fresh participants
4 Live	Wk 7–9	Real service, limited hours	Does it hold up under pressure?	Baseline measures + workflow impact

Participants: 6–8 employees, with support staff present where appropriate. Same participants through iterative rounds where possible, plus fresh participants in retesting.

How I'd run the testing

01

Observe, don't assume.
Task-based testing first;
conversation afterwards.

02

**Test the design, not
the person.**
If someone struggles,
investigate what the
design is asking of them.

03

**Give the concept
permission to fail.**
Predefine what evidence
would make us iterate,
pivot or stop.

Defining success

Problem

Discover

Define

Make/Test

Learn/Iterate

Reflect

Primary user goal

Has the PoC increased independence and confidence for the employee?

Secondary user goal

Have customers enjoyed a simple, friction-free restaurant experience?

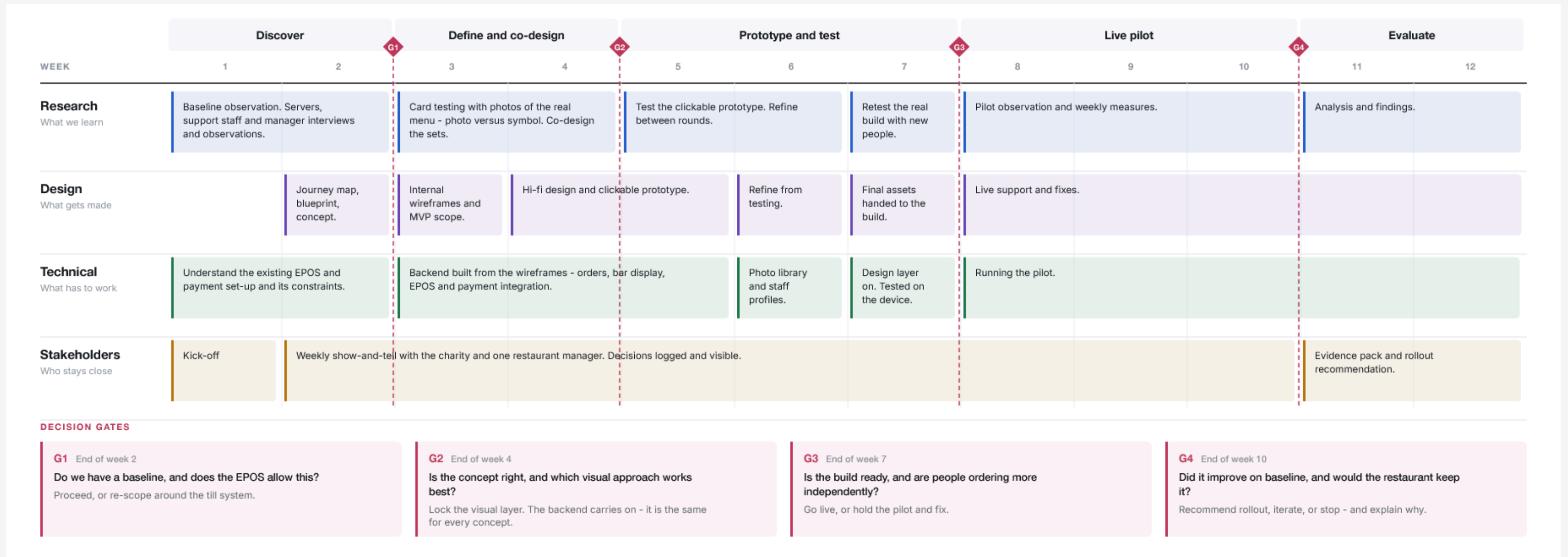
Business goal - restaurant

Does it work commercially and operationally?

Business goal - charity

Can it scale to more restaurants? And create more paid jobs (we can't prove this in 12 weeks)

8-12 week roadmap



Question time...

mostlycaroline.com

mostlycaroline.com/cgi

[Prototype](#) [Figma](#) [Make](#)